Anger

Is it the thing that happened, or what I tell myself about it?

READING · TWO SHORT PASSAGES

Epictetus, *Enchiridion* 5: we aren't disturbed by things, but by our judgments about them. **Seneca, *On Anger* 2.4** (Book II, chapter 4): anger comes in three movements: an involuntary jolt, a judgment we agree to, and a passion we can't control. We can step in at the second.

BEFORE THE MEETING

Announce on your Substack. Ask people to notice one moment of irritation during the week.

Open · 10	Read · 10	Discuss · 45	Practice · 15	Close · 10
Ground rules; welcome newcomers	Aloud, together	The questions below	Rewrite one judgment	One takeaway each

DISCUSSION QUESTIONS

1. Recall a recent moment of anger. What happened, and what did you tell yourself about it?
2. Seneca says the first jolt isn't up to us, but agreeing to it is. In your example, where could you have stepped in?
3. Seneca thought anger is never useful. Do you agree?
4. What's the difference between anger and a firm, fair response?
5. What would a pause change: counting, walking away, sleeping on it?

PRACTICE THIS MONTH

Catch the second movement. When you feel the jolt, finish the sentence "I'm telling myself that…" before you act. Then ask whether it's true.

FACILITATOR'S MOVE

"Can you give an example?" Talk about anger stays vague until someone describes a real moment.

NOTES